unquestioned vision. With the uneasy situation with China now public knowledge, the prime minister had to take steps to ensure that the border stayed strong. Had he not done so, it is quite likely that today India would have neither Arunachal nor Eastern Ladakh under its control.

Says Subrahmanyam in defence of the Forward Policy: ‘Those who criticize this policy have not suggested what alternative course the Government of India should have adopted. Do they suggest that the government should have left this area un-patrolled and with no check-posts at all?’ It is perhaps worth pointing out that at that time the Chinese claim over Aksai Chin was precisely that—there were no Indian checkposts at Aksai Chin to suggest that the territory belonged to India. The fact that there were no Chinese or Tibetan or Sinkiang checkposts either did not seem to matter to them. After the fateful events of 1962 it is perhaps possible to say that the Chinese appeared to be satisfied after reaching their second claim line—but in 1959, it was impossible to be sure of this.

The problem that arose from having announced the Forward Policy was entirely different. Nehru’s tendency to make grandiose statements in Parliament or elsewhere seemed to be aimed at his critics within India and the media, who had started asking uncomfortable questions. Nehru had demonstrated time and again his tendency to announce policy decisions that would leave the concerned establishment running to catch up.

Had Nehru paused long enough to understand the implications of Exercise Lal Qila and the common sense behind Thorat’s defensive line, he may well have still adopted the Forward Policy, but left its implementation to the Assam Rifles in NEFA and Sikkim and the Border Police in Ladakh. These lightly held positions would have, as envisaged in Thorat’s plan, fallen back to where the army was waiting for the Chinese. Instead, Nehru brought in the army with the intention of holding ground, in the process forgetting that armies are meant to fight and not just hold ground.

7 BRIGADE DEPLOYS

We shall return to Ladakh in the Western Sector and Walong in the Lohit Frontier Division in subsequent chapters. For the present, our focus must remain on the Bomdila–Dirang Dzong–Se-la–Tawang and Nam Ka Chu areas, which were a part of the Kameng Frontier Division. When looked at from the Chinese side, the closest post in this region was Khenzemane, situated south of the McMahon Line along the north-south flowing